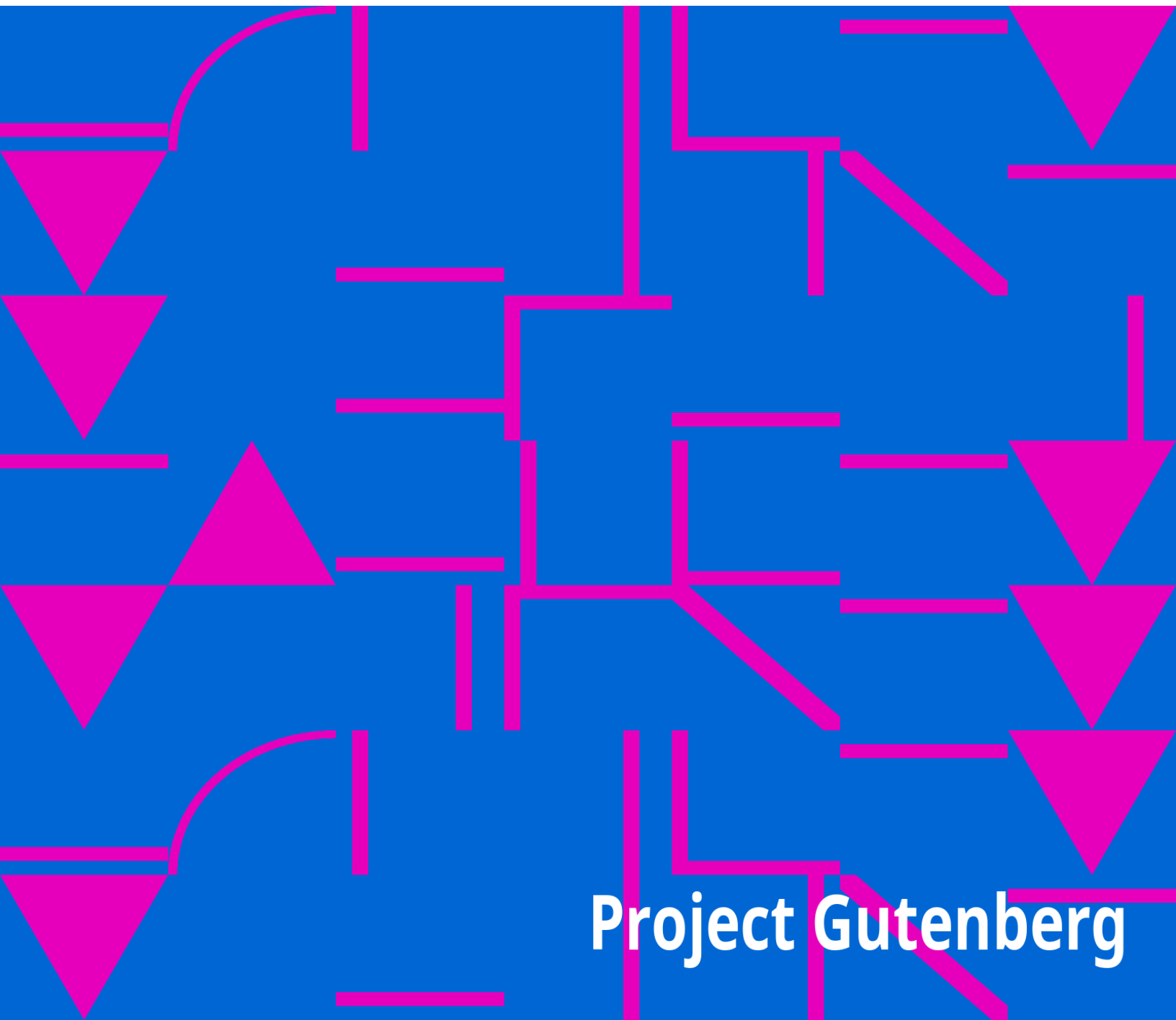


# Ruthless Rhymes for Heartless Homes

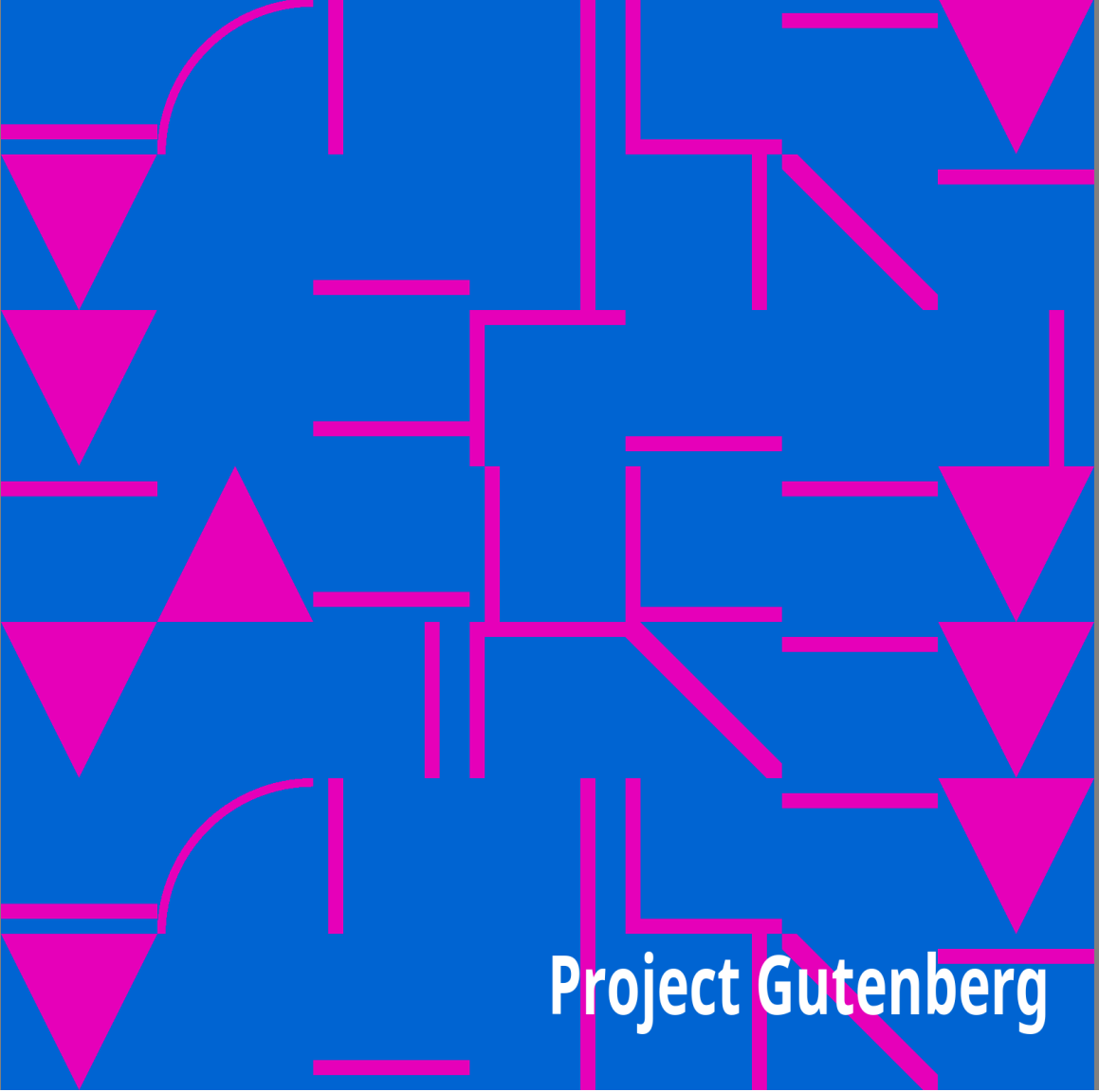
Harry Graham

The bottom half of the image features a vibrant blue background adorned with a complex, abstract pattern of magenta geometric shapes. This pattern includes a variety of line segments—some horizontal, some vertical, and some at diagonal angles—as well as several triangles of different sizes and orientations. Some of these shapes are solid magenta, while others are formed by magenta outlines. The overall effect is a dynamic, modern, and somewhat chaotic visual texture.

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# Ruthless Rhymes for Heartless Homes

Harry Graham



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RHYMES FOR HEARTLESS HOMES \*\*\*

# **Ruthless Rhymes for Heartless Homes**

**By**

## Col. D. Streamer (Harry Graham)



*"I was unlucky with my wives,  
So are the most of married men;  
Undoubtedly they lost their lives,—"*

---

**RUTHLESS  
RHYMES *for***

# Heartless Homes

By Col. D. STREAMER



New York  
R. H. RUSSELL  
1902

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*Copyright, 1901, by Robert Howard Russell  
Second impression, December, 1902*

---

## Dedicated to P. P.

*("Qui connait son sourire a connu le parfait.")*

I NEED no Comments of the Press,  
No critic's cursory caress,  
No paragraphs my book to bless  
    With praise, or ban with curses,  
So long as You, for whom I write,  
Whose single notice I invite,  
Are still sufficiently polite  
    To smile upon my verses.

If You should seek for Ruthless Rhymes  
(In memory of Western climes),  
And, for the sake of olden times,  
    Obtain this new edition,  
You must not be surprised a bit,  
Nor even deem the act unfit,  
That I have dedicated it  
    To You, without permission.

P. T. O.[\[1\]](#)

And if You chance to ask me why,  
It is sufficient, I reply,  
That You are You, and I am I,—  
    To put the matter briefly.  
That I should dedicate to You  
Can only interest us two;  
The fact remains, then, that I do,  
    Because I want to—chiefly.

And if these verses can beguile

From those grey eyes of yours a smile,  
You will have made it well worth while  
To seek your approbation;  
No further meed  
Of praise they need,  
But must succeed,  
And do indeed,  
If they but lead  
You on to read  
Beyond the Dedication.

1901.

H.

G.

---



## Author's Preface

WITH guilty, conscience-stricken tears  
I offer up these rhymes of mine  
To children of maturer years  
(From Seventeen to Ninety-nine).  
A special solace may they be  
In days of second infancy.

The frenzied mother who observes  
This volume in her offspring's hand,  
And trembles for the darling's nerves,  
Must please to clearly understand,  
If baby suffers by-and-bye  
The Artist is to blame, not *I*!

But should the little brat survive,  
And fatten on the Ruthless Rhyme,  
To raise a Heartless Home and thrive  
Through a successful life of crime,  
The Artist hopes that you will see  
That *I* am to be thanked, not *he*!

P. T. O.[\[1\]](#)

Fond parent, you whose children are  
Of tender age (from two to eight),  
Pray keep this little volume far  
From reach of such, and relegate  
My verses to an upper shelf,—  
Where you may study them yourself.



### **FOOTNOTE:**

[\[1\]](#) Transcriber's Note: P.T.O. means please turn over. This is retained in the text although the instruction is not necessary.

---



*"He had such good cigars."*

---

## Uncle Joe

**A**N Angel bore dear Uncle Joe  
To rest beyond the stars.  
I miss him, oh! I miss him so,—  
He had *such* good cigars.



## Impetuous Samuel

**S**AM had spirits naught could check,  
And to-day, at breakfast, he  
Broke his baby sister's neck,  
So he shan't have jam for tea!



## Inconsiderate Hannah

**N**AUGHTY little Hannah said  
She could make her grandma whistle,  
So, that night, inside her bed  
Placed some nettles and a thistle.

Though dear grandma quite infirm is,  
Heartless Hannah watched her settle,  
With her poor old epidermis  
Resting up against a nettle.

Suddenly she reached the thistle!  
My! you should have heard her whistle!

• • • • •  
A successful plan was Hannah's,  
But I cannot praise her manners.

---

## Aunt Eliza

**I**N the drinking-well  
    (Which the plumber built her)  
Aunt Eliza fell,—  
    We must buy a filter.



## Self-Sacrifice

FATHER, chancing to chastise  
His indignant daughter Sue,  
Said, "I hope you realize  
That this hurts me more than you."

Susan straightway ceased to roar.  
"If that's really true," said she,  
"I can stand a good deal more;  
Pray go on, and don't mind me."





# La Course Interrompue

I.

**J** EAN qui allait a Dijon  
(Il montait en bicyclette)  
Rencontra un gros lion  
Qui se faisait la toilette.

II.

Voila Jean qui tombe a terre  
Et le lion le digère!

• • • • •  
Mon Dieu! Que c'est embêtant!  
Il me devait quatre francs.





*"John had on some clothes of mine;  
I can almost see them shrinking  
Washed repeatedly in brine."*

---

## John

JOHN, across the broad Atlantic,  
Tried to navigate a barque,  
But he met an unromantic  
And extremely hungry shark.

John (I blame his childhood's teachers)  
Thought to treat this as a lark,  
Ignorant of how these creatures  
Do delight to bite a barque.

Said "This animal's a bore!" and,  
With a scornful sort of grin,  
Handled an adjacent oar and  
Chucked it underneath the chin.

At this unexpected juncture  
Which he had not reckoned on,  
Mr. Shark he made a puncture  
In the barque—and then in John.

Sad am I, and sore at thinking  
John had on some clothes of mine;  
I can almost see them shrinking,  
Washed repeatedly in brine.

I shall never cease regretting  
That I lent my hat to him,  
For I fear a thorough wetting  
Cannot well improve the brim.

Oh! to know a shark is browsing,  
Boldly, blandly on my boots!

Coldly, cruelly carousing  
On the choicest of my suits!

Creatures I regard with loathing  
Who can calmly take their fill  
Of one's Jæger underclothing:—  
Down, my aching heart, be still!

---

## The Fond Father

O F Baby I was very fond,  
She'd won her father's heart;  
So, when she fell into the pond,  
It gave me quite a start.



## Necessity

LATE last night I slew my wife,  
    Stretched her on the parquet flooring;  
I was loath to take her life,  
    But I *had* to stop her snoring.



## Unselfishness

ALL those who see my children say,  
"What sweet, what kind, what charming  
elves!"

They are so thoughtful, too, for they  
Are *always* thinking of themselves.  
It must be ages since I ceased  
To wonder which I liked the least.

Such is their generosity,  
That, when the roof began to fall,  
They would not share the risk with me,  
But said, "No, father, take it all!"  
Yet I should love them more, I know,  
If I did not dislike them so.



## Scorching John

**J** OHN, who rode his Dunlop tire  
O'er the head of sweet Maria,  
When she writhed in frightful pain,  
Had to blow it out again.





## Misfortunes Never Come Singly

**M**AKING toast at the fireside,  
Nurse fell in the grate and died;  
And, what makes it ten times worse,  
All the toast was burned *with* nurse.



## The Perils of Obesity

**Y**ESTERDAY my gun exploded  
When I thought it wasn't loaded;  
Near my wife I pressed the trigger,  
Chipped a fragment off her figure;  
'Course I'm sorry, and all that,  
But she shouldn't be so fat.





*"Now, although the room grows chilly,  
I haven't the heart to poke poor Billy."*

---

## Tender-Heartedness

**B**ILLY, in one of his nice new sashes,  
Fell in the fire and was burnt to ashes;  
Now, although the room grows chilly,  
I haven't the heart to poke poor Billy.



## Jim; or, the Deferred Luncheon Party

WHEN the line he tried to cross,  
The express ran into Jim;  
Bitterly I mourn his loss—  
I was to have lunched with him.



## Appreciation

**A** UNTIE, did you feel no pain  
Falling from that apple tree?  
Will you do it, please, again?  
'Cos my friend here didn't see.



## Baby

**B**ABY in the caldron fell,—  
See the grief on Mother's brow;  
Mother loved her darling well,—  
Darling's quite hard-boiled by now.





*"Darling's quite hard-boiled by now."*

---



## Nurse's Mistake

**N**URSE, who peppered baby's face  
    (She mistook it for a muffin),  
Held her tongue and kept her place,  
    "Laying low and sayin' nuffin";  
Mother, seeing baby blinded,  
    Said, "Oh, nurse, how absent-minded!"



## The Stern Parent

FATHER heard his Children scream,  
So he threw them in the stream,  
Saying, as he drowned the third,  
"Children should be seen, *not* heard!"



## "Bluebeard"

YES, I am Bluebeard, and my name  
Is one that children cannot stand;  
Yet once I used to be so tame  
I'd eat out of a person's hand;  
So gentle was I wont to be  
A Curate might have played with me.

People accord me little praise,  
Yet I am not the least alarming;  
I can recall, in bygone days,  
A maid once said she thought me charming.  
She was my friend,—no more I vow,—  
And—she's in an asylum now.

Girls used to clamour for my hand,  
Girls I refused in simple dozens;  
I said I'd be their brother, and  
They promised they would be my cousins.  
(One, I accepted,—more or less—  
But I've forgotten her address.)

They worried me like anything  
By their proposals ev'ry day,  
Until at last I had to ring  
The bell, and have them cleared away;  
(I often pondered on the cost  
Of getting them completely lost.)

To share my somewhat lofty rank  
Was what they panted for, like mad;  
You see my balance at the bank  
Was not so small, and, I may add,

A Castle, Gothic and immense,  
Is my Official Residence.

It overlooks a many a mile  
Of park, of gardens and domains;  
I'm staying now in lodgings, while  
They're doing up the—well—the drains,—  
For they began to give offence  
At my Official Residence.

And, when I entertain at home,  
I hardly ever fail to please,  
The "upper tens" alone may come  
To join in my "recherché" teas;  
I am a King in ev'ry sense  
At my Official Residence.

My dances, on a parquet floor,  
My royal dinners, which consist  
Of fifteen courses, sometimes more,  
Are things that are not lightly missed;  
In fact I do not spare expense  
At my Official Residence.

My hospitality to those  
Whom I invite to come and stay  
Is famed; my wine like water flows,  
Exactly like, some people say,  
But this is mere impertinence  
At my Official Residence.

When through the streets I walk about  
My subjects stand and kiss their hands,  
Raise a refined metallic shout,  
Wave flags and warble tunes on bands,  
While bunting hangs on ev'ry front,—  
With my commands to let it bunt.

When I come home again, of course,  
Retainers are employed to cheer,  
My paid domestics get quite hoarse  
Acclaiming me, and you can hear  
The welkin ringing to the sky,—  
Aye, aye, and let it welk, say I!

And yet, in spite of this, there are  
Some persons who, at diff'rent times,  
—(Because I am so popular)—  
Accuse me of most awful crimes;  
A girl once said I was a flirt!  
Oh my! how the expression hurt!

I *never* flirted in the least,  
Never for very long, I mean,—  
Ask any lady (now deceased)  
Who partner of my life has been;—  
Oh well, of course, sometimes, perhaps,  
I meet a girl, like other chaps.

And, if I like her very much,  
And if she cares for me a bit,  
Where is the harm of look or touch  
If neither of us mentions it?  
It isn't right, I don't suppose,  
But no one's hurt if no one knows!

And, if I placed my hand below  
Her chin and raised her face an inch,  
And then proceeded—well, you know,—  
(Excuse the vulgarism)—to clinch;  
It would be wrong without a doubt,  
That is, if anyone found out.

But then, remember, Life is short

And Woman's Arts are very long,  
And sometimes when one didn't ought  
One knowingly commits a wrong;  
Well—speaking for myself, of course,  
I almost always feel remorse.

One should not break one's self *too* fast  
Of little habits of this sort,  
Which may be definitely classed  
With gambling or a taste for port;  
They should be *slowly* dropped, until  
The Heart is subject to the Will.

I knew a man on Seventh Street  
Who, at a very slight expense,  
By persevering, was complete-  
Ly cured of total abstinence;  
An altered life he has begun  
And takes a horn with anyone.

I knew another man whose wife  
Was an invet'rate suicide,  
She daily strove to take her life  
And (naturally) nearly died;  
But some such system she essayed,  
And now she's eighty in the shade.

Ah, the new leaves I try to turn,  
But, like so many men in town,  
I seem, as with regret I learn,  
Merely to turn the corner down;  
A habit which I fear, alack!  
Makes it more easy to turn back.

I have been criticised a lot;  
I venture to enquire what for;  
Because, forsooth, I have not got

The instincts of a bachelor!  
Just hear my story, you will find  
How grossly I have been maligned.

I was unlucky with my wives,  
So are the most of married men;  
Undoubtedly they lost their lives,—  
Of course, but even so, what then?  
I loved them dearly, understand,  
And I *can* love, to beat the band.

My first was little Emmeline,  
More beautiful than day was she;  
Her proud, aristocratic mien  
Was what at once attracted me.  
I naturally did not know  
That I should soon dislike her so.

But there it was! And you'll infer  
I had not very long to wait  
Before my red-hot love for her  
Turned to unutterable hate.  
So, when this state of things I found,  
I naturally had her drowned.

My next was Sarah, sweet but shy,  
And quite inordinately meek;  
Yes, even now I wonder why  
I had her hanged within the week.  
Perhaps I felt a bit upset,  
Or else she bored me, I forget.

Then came Evangeline, my third,  
And, when I chanced to be away,  
She, so I subsequently heard,  
Was wont (I deeply grieve to say)  
With my small retinue to flirt.

I strangled her. I hope it hurt.

Isabel was, I think, my next,—  
    (That is, if I remember right)—  
And I was really very vexed  
    To find her hair come off at night;  
To falsehood I could not connive,  
And so I had her boiled alive.

Then came Sophia, I believe,  
    Her coiffure was at least her own,  
Alas! she fancied to deceive  
    Her friends by altering its tone.  
She dyed her locks a flaming red!  
I suffocated her in bed.

Susannah Maud was number six;  
    But she did not survive a day;  
Poor Sue, she had no parlour tricks  
    And hardly anything to say.  
A little strychnine in her tea  
Finished her off, and I was free.

Yet I did not despair, and soon!  
    In spite of failures, started off  
Upon my seventh honeymoon  
    With Jane; but could not stand her cough.  
'Twas chronic. Kindness was in vain.  
I pushed her underneath the train.

Well, after her, I married Kate.  
    A most unpleasant woman. Oh!  
I caught her at the garden gate  
    Kissing a man I didn't know;  
And, as that didn't suit me quite,  
I blew her up with dynamite.



Most married men, so sorely tried  
As this, would have been rather bored.  
Not I, but chose another bride  
And married Ruth. Alas! she snored!  
I served her just the same as Kate,  
And so she joined the other eight.

My last was Grace; I am not clear,  
I *think* she didn't like me much;  
She used to scream when I came near,  
And shuddered at my lightest touch.  
She seemed to wish to keep aloof,  
And so I threw her off the roof.

This is the point I wish to make:—  
From all the wives for whom I grieve,  
Whose lives I had perforce to take,  
Not one complaint did I receive;  
And no expense was spared to please  
My spouses at their obsequies.

My habits, I would have you know,  
Are perfect, as they've always been;  
You ask if I am good, and go  
To church, and keep my fingers clean?  
I do, I mean to say I am,  
I have the morals of a lamb.

In my domains there is no sin,  
Virtue is rampant all the time,  
Since I so thoughtfully brought in  
A bill which legalizes crime;  
Committing things that are not wrong  
Must pall before so very long.

And if what you imagine vice  
Is not considered so at all,

Crime doesn't seem the least bit nice,  
There's no temptation then to fall;  
For half the charm of things we do  
Is knowing that we oughtn't to.

Believe me, then, I am not bad,  
Though in my youth I had to trek  
Because I happened to have had  
Some difficulties with a cheque.  
What forgery in some might be  
Is absentmindedness in me!

I know that I was much abused,  
No doubt when I was young and rash,  
But I should not have been accused  
Of misappropriating cash.  
I may have sneaked a silver dish;—  
Well, you may search me if you wish!

So, now you see me, more or less,  
As I would figure in your thoughts;  
A trifle given to excess  
And prone perhaps to vice of sorts;  
When tempted, rather apt to fall,  
But still—a good chap after all!



# The Cat

*(Advice to the Young)*

**M**Y children, you should imitate  
The harmless, necessary cat,  
Who eats whatever's on his plate,  
And doesn't even leave the fat;  
Who never stays in bed too late,  
Or does immoral things like that;  
Instead of saying "Shan't!" or "Bosh!"  
He'll sit and wash, and wash, and wash!

When shadows fall and lights grow dim  
He sits beneath the kitchen stair;  
Regardless as to life and limb,  
A simple couch he chooses there;  
And if you tumble over him,  
He simply loves to hear you swear.  
And, while bad language *you* prefer,  
He'll sit and purr, and purr, and purr!



*The Cat.*

---

## The Children's "Don't"

*D*ON'T tell Papa his nose is red  
As any rosebud or geranium,  
Forbear to eye his hairless head  
Or criticise his cootlike cranium;  
'Tis years of sorrow and of care  
Have made his head come through his hair.

*Don't* give your endless guinea-pig  
(Wherein that animal may build a  
Sufficient nest) the Sunday wig  
Of poor, dear, dull, deaf Aunt Matilda.  
Oh, *don't* tie strings across her path,  
Or empty beetles in her bath!

*Don't* ask your uncle why he's fat;  
Avoid upon his toe-joints treading;  
*Don't* hide a hedgehog in his hat,  
Or bury bushes in his bedding.  
He will not see the slightest sport  
In pepper put into his port!

*Don't* pull away the cherished chair  
On which Mamma intended sitting,  
Nor yet prepare her session there  
By setting on the seat her knitting;  
Pause ere you hurt her spine, I pray—  
That is a game that *two* can play.

My children, never, never steal!  
To know their offspring is a thief  
Will often make a father feel  
Annoyed and cause a mother grief;

So never steal, but, when you do,  
Be sure there's no one watching you.



*"Don't hide a hedgehog in his hat."*

Perhaps you have a turn for what  
Is known as "misappropriation,"  
Attractions this has doubtless got  
For persons of a certain station,  
But prevalent 'twill never be

Among the aristocracy.

Of course, suppose you want a thing  
    (The owner's absent), and you borrow  
A ruby ring; you mean to bring  
    Your friend his trinket back to-morrow  
Meanwhile you have the stones reset,  
Lest he forget! Lest he forget!

And if some rude detective's hand  
    Should find beneath your cloak a roll  
Of muslin, or a cruet-stand  
    That's labelled "Hotel Metropole,"  
With kindly smile you hand them back,  
A harmless Kleptomaniac!

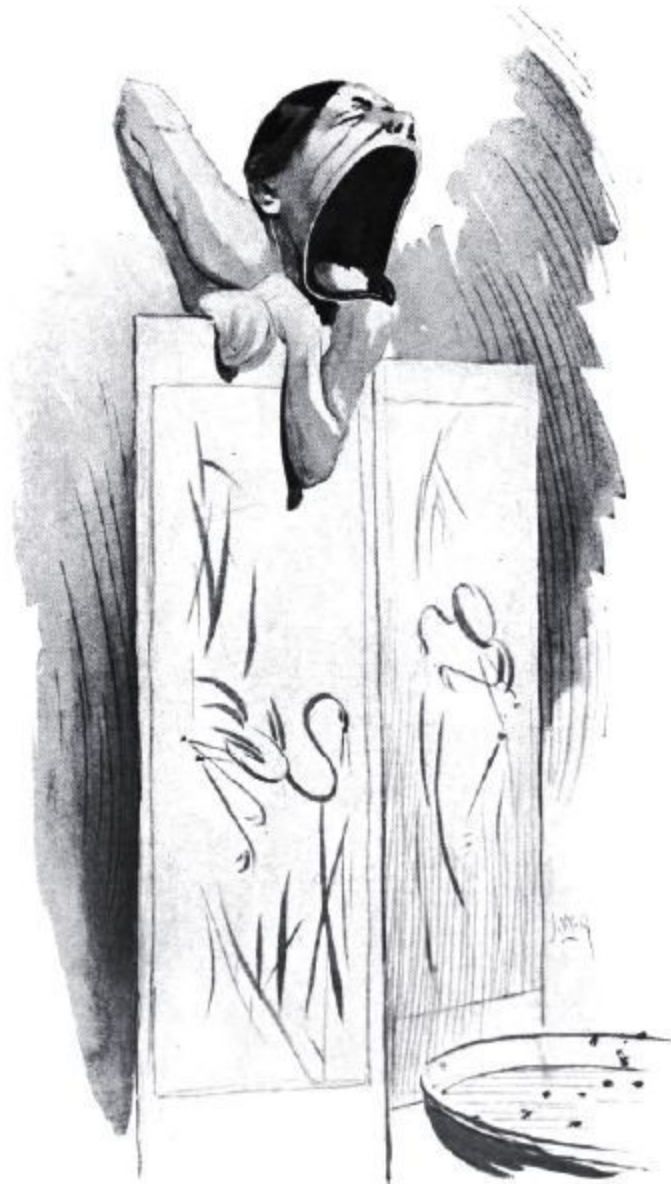
. . . . .

Don't tell a lie! Some men I've known  
    Commit the most appalling acts,  
Because they happen to be prone  
    To an economy of facts;  
And if *to lie* is bad, no doubt  
'Tis even worse *to get found out!*

. . . . .

Don't take the life of any one,  
    However horrid he may be;  
That sort of thing is never done,  
    Not in the best society,  
Where even parricide is thought  
A most unfilial kind of sport.

Among the "Upper Ten" to-day,  
    It is considered want of tact  
To slay one's kith and kin, and may  
    Be classed as an "unfriendly act."  
Oh, yes, of course I know that this  
Is merely public prejudice.



*"Or empty beetles in her bath!"*

But ever since the world began,  
Howe'er well meant his motives are,  
The man who slays his fellow man  
Is never really popular,  
Whether he sins from love of crime,  
Or merely just to pass the time.





## Envoi

**S**PEED, Ruthless Rhymes; throughout the land  
Disperse yourselves with patient zeal!  
Go, perch upon the Critic's hand,  
Just after he has had a meal.  
But should he still unkindly be,  
Unperch and hasten back to me.

And, wheresoever you may roam,  
Remember the secluded shelf  
(Where, sitting in his Heartless Home,  
The author chortles to himself),  
There, in the distant by-and-bye,  
You still may flutter back—to die.



\*\*\* END OF THE PROJECT GUTENBERG EBOOK RUTHLESS  
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